

What Do We Mean When We Talk About Polarization?



Tristan Muno – Trilateral Summer Academy 2026, uOttawa
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About me

- Born in Mainz, finished high school in 2018
- Helped logistically at an earlier version of (back then a bilateral) summer institute in 2018
- B.Ed. History & Pol. Science, M.A. Pol Science, since 2025 PhD at Uni Mannheim
- The building I actually work in:



Agenda

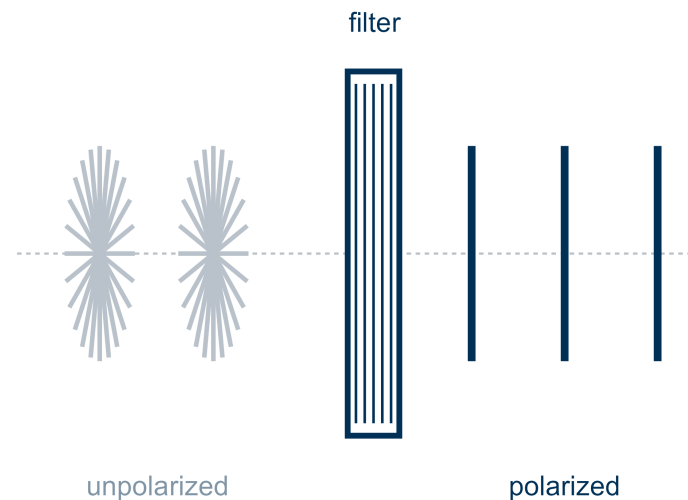
1. The concept – a family, not a thing
2. From political to affective polarization
3. Social identity theory
4. Measuring affective polarization
5. Affective polarization in Europe – Hahm et al. (2024)
6. Takeaways
7. Where I go from here – ongoing projects (if time)

The Concept

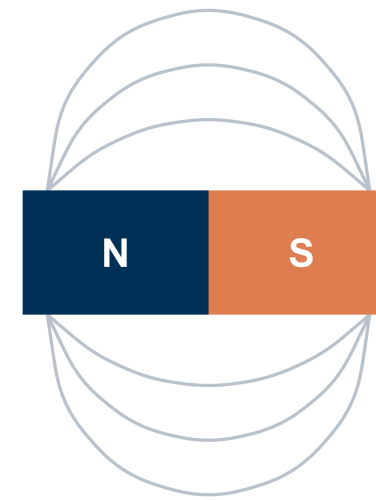
A word borrowed from physics

- Physics: polarization is the *orientation* of a wave
- Original meaning: alignment, orientation, separation
- Nothing about conflict or hostility – social science supplied that

Light: aligned in one plane

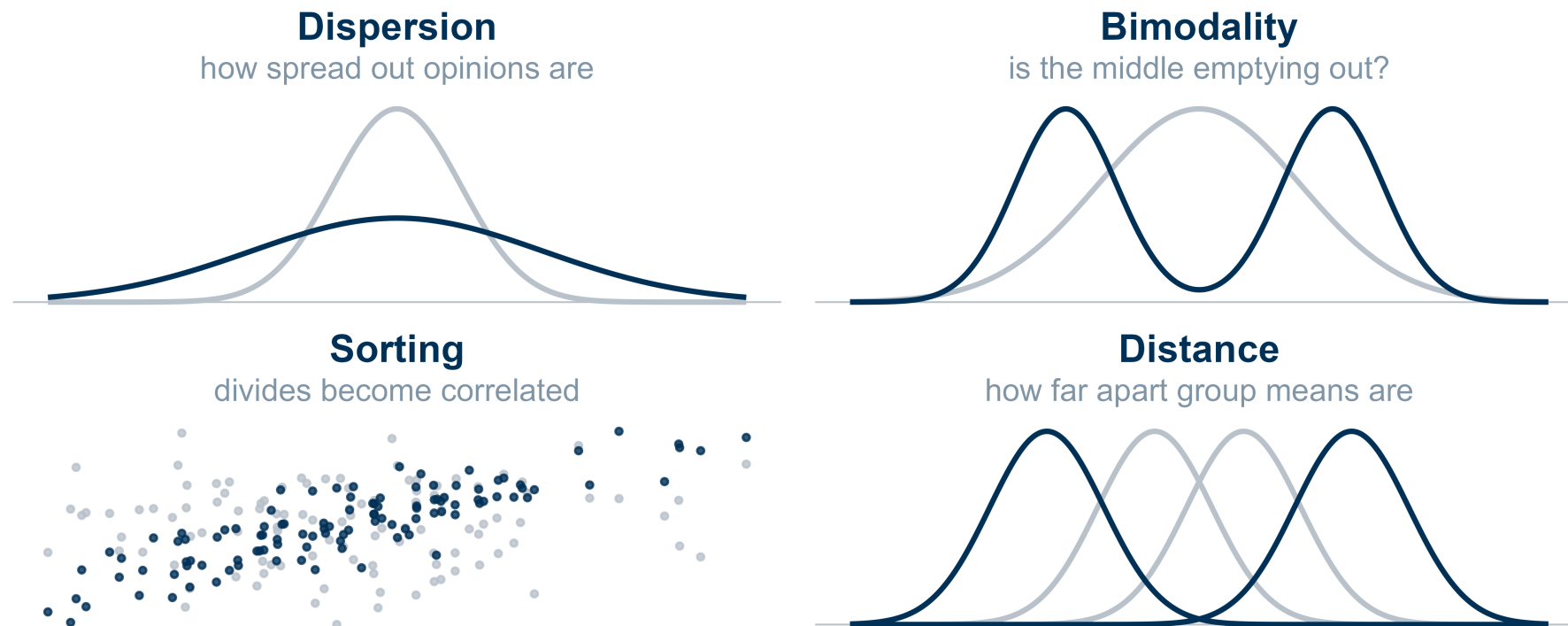


Magnet: two poles



Polarization is a family of concepts

- Broadest usage: alignment, separation, sorting, divergence
- Four mathematically distinct things share the name
- They can move in **opposite directions in the same data**



Three further axes

- Bipolar vs multipolar – nothing requires two camps
- State vs process – a snapshot vs a trend
- Object vs target – who is polarized against whom?

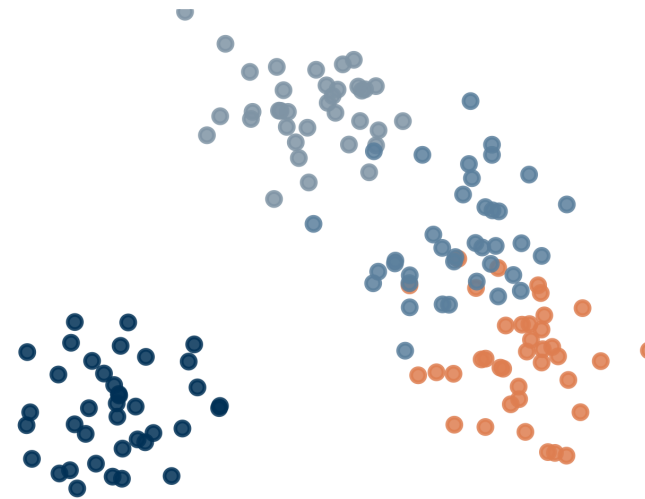
Bipolar

two camps on one dimension



Multipolar

several camps, several dimensions



From Political to Affective Polarization

The debate on political polarization

- Originally *ideological*: divergence on issues or left-right
- Elite level: clear US congressional divergence since the 1970s
- Mass level: fiercely contested through the 2000s
- Fiorina et al. (2008) – better sorted, not more extreme
- Abramowitz and Saunders (2008) – genuinely polarized, especially the engaged

Affect, not ideology

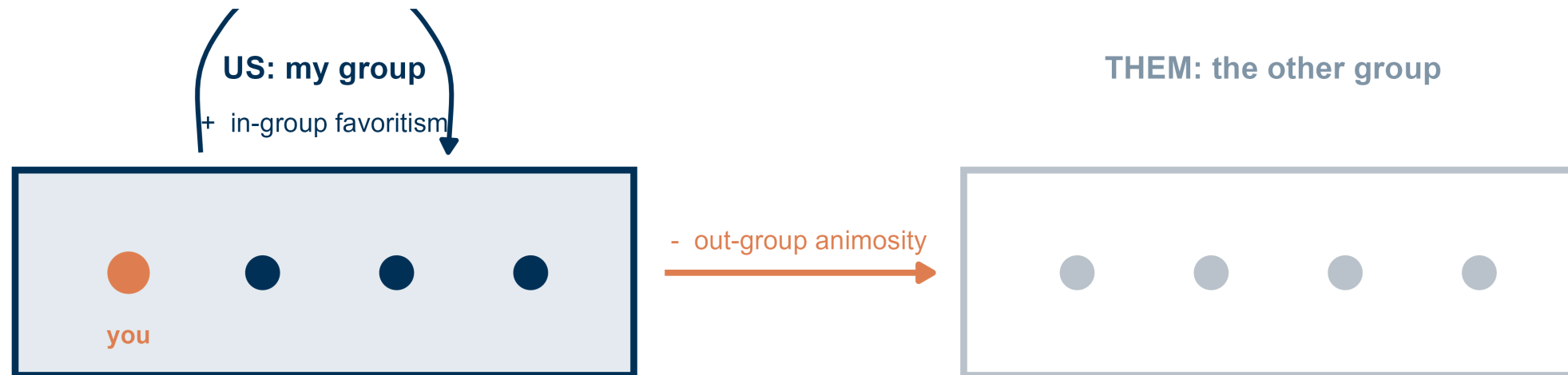
- Iyengar et al. (2012): ask how partisans *feel*, not where they stand
- Dislike substantially exceeds substantive disagreement
- Iyengar and Westwood (2015): partisan discrimination exceeds racial discrimination
- Two components: in-group favoritism **and** out-group animosity

“the tendency of people identifying as [partisans] to view opposing partisans negatively and copartisans positively” (Iyengar and Westwood 2015; Iyengar et al. 2019)

Social Identity Theory

Why would affect exceed disagreement?

- Humans are social beings – we know ourselves through our groups
- Group membership becomes part of the self: a **social identity** (Tajfel and Turner 1979)
- So we divide the world into **us** and **them**
- We favour our own and derogate the other – *without deciding to*
- Everyday version: sport teams – no policy disagreement required
- Even **arbitrary, random** groups trigger it (Tajfel et al. 1971)



one mechanism, two components

Three implications

1. **Partisanship as a social identity** / expressive partisanship (Huddy et al. 2015): a party is something you *are*, not just a set of positions you hold
2. **In-group love $\neq$ out-group hate** (Brewer 1999): favoritism does not require derogation – the two are separable, and AP is the presence of **both**. Hence also *negative* partisanship: identifying **against** a party (Abramowitz and Webster 2018; Medeiros and Noël 2014)
3. **Multiparty Europe is harder** (Roccas and Brewer 2002; Röllicke 2023): what counts as in- and out-group? Identities may span several parties, broader coalitions, or ideological blocs

Measuring Affective Polarization

The workhorse

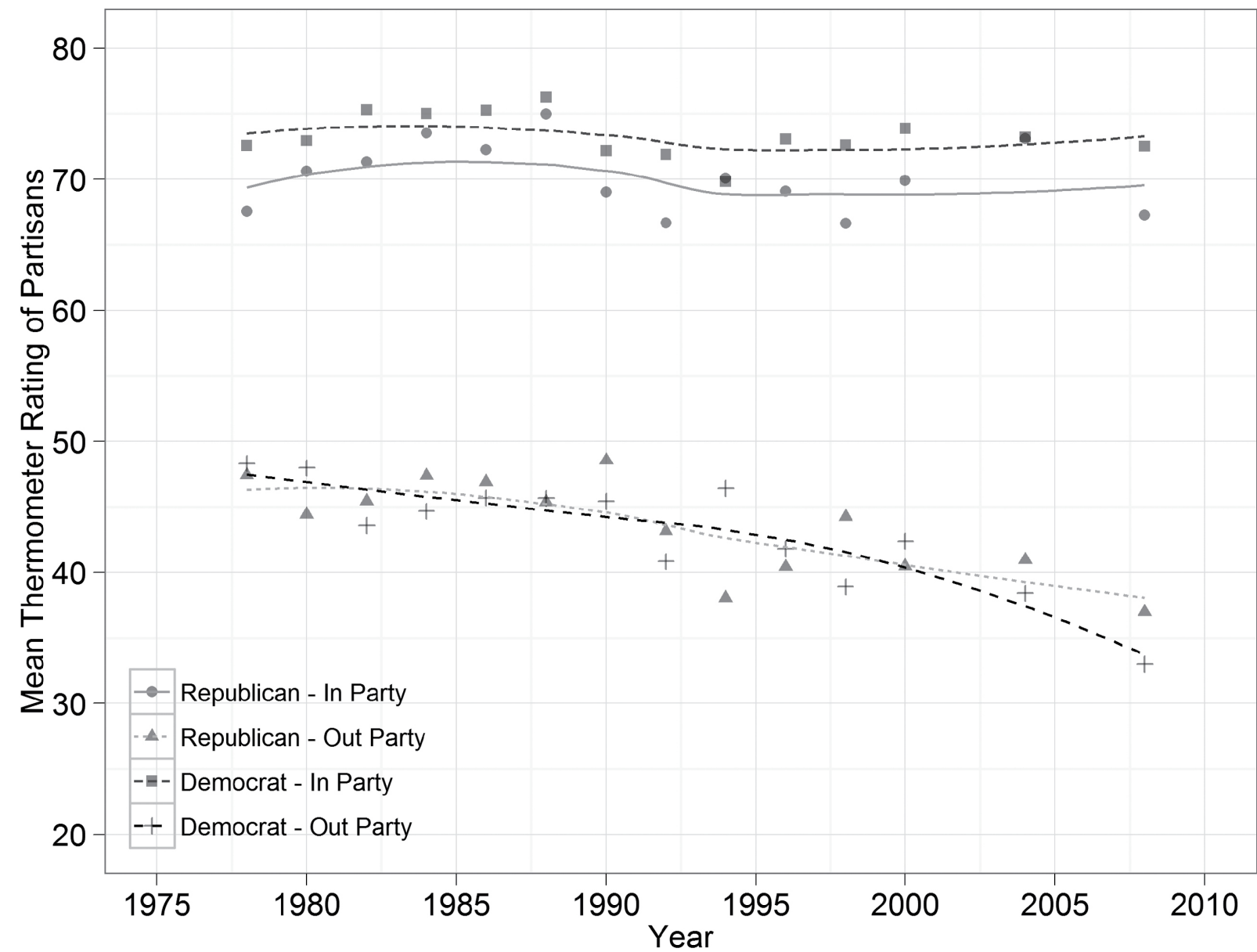
- Feeling thermometers / like-dislike scales: rate each party 0–10 (or 0–100)
- Simplest AP measure: in-group score minus out-group score

"How much do you like or dislike each of the following parties?"

Party A	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Party B	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Party C	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Party D	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○

0 strongly dislike 10 strongly like

The thermometer in action



Note: Figure from Iyengar et al. (2012).

API: mean distance from your party

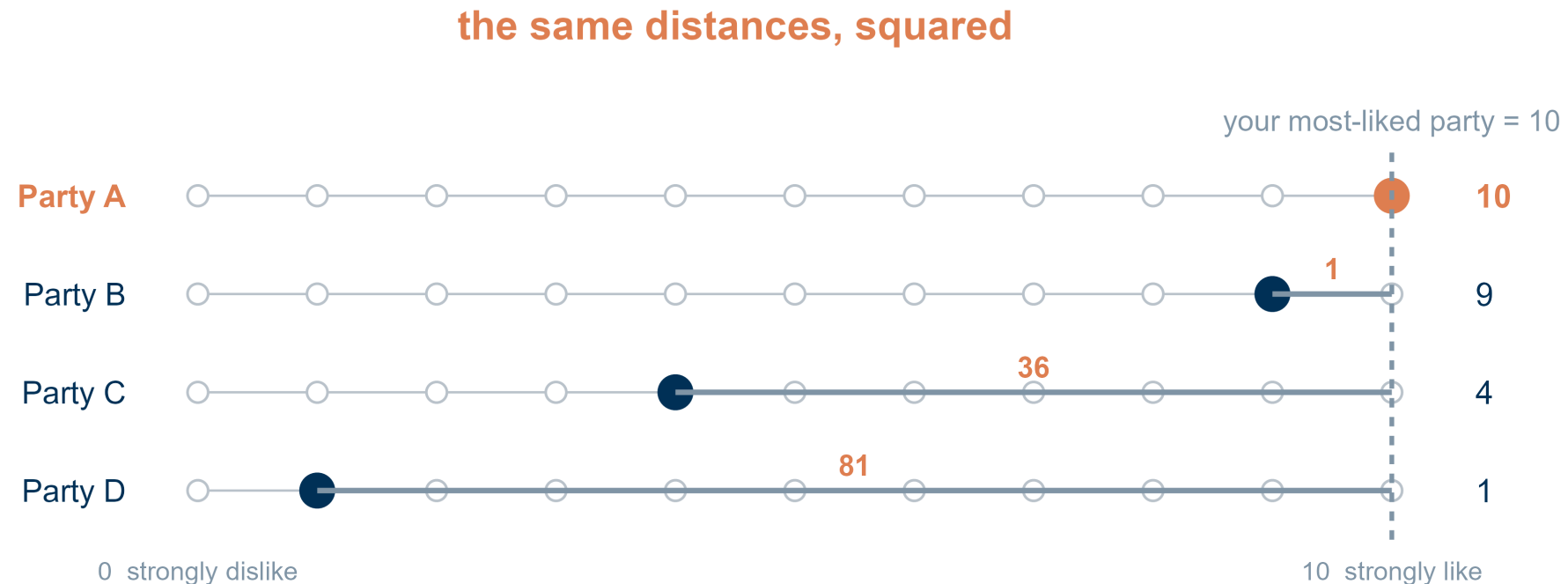
- With many parties there is no single “the other party” to subtract
- Reiljan (2020): the **mean distance** from your party to each of the others – distances enter **unsquared**



$$API_i = L_{\text{own}} - \bar{L}_{\text{others}} = 10 - \frac{9 + 4 + 1}{3} = 10 - \frac{14}{3} = \mathbf{5.33}$$

Distance: the same distances, squared

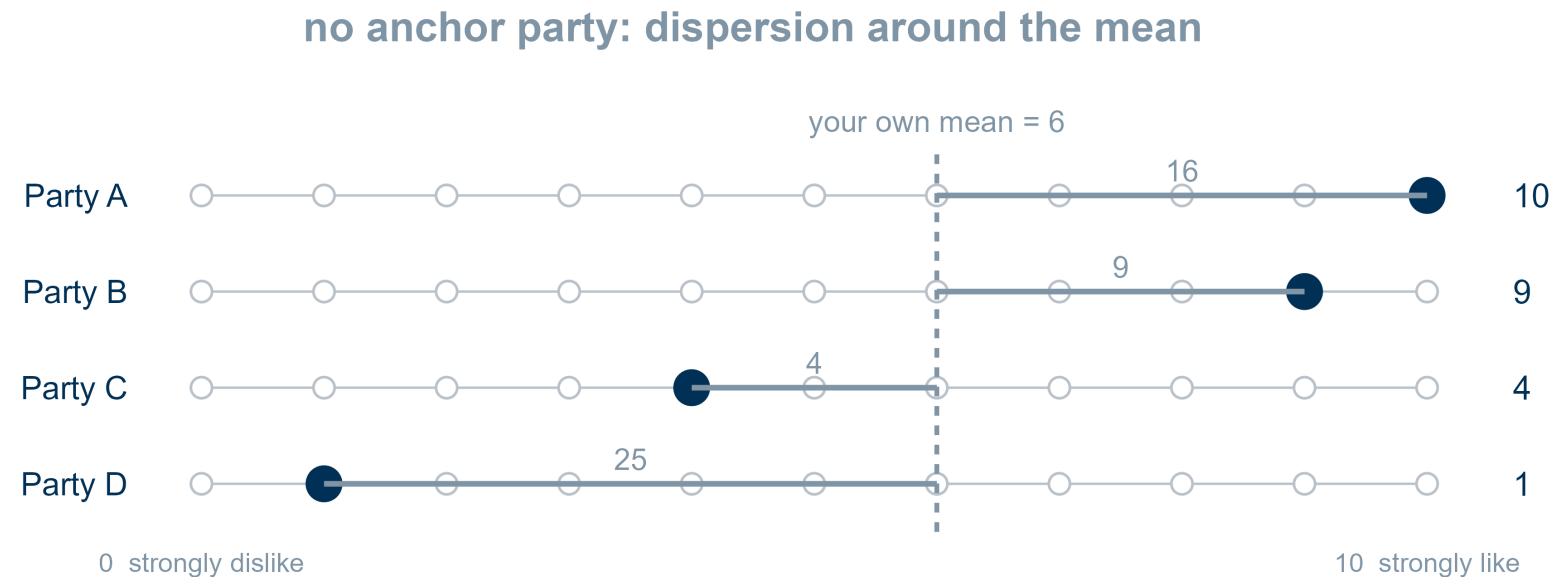
- Wagner (2021): the **root-mean-square distance** from your most-liked party to each of the others
- Same anchor, same three parties as API – the only difference is **squaring**



$$\text{Distance}_i = \sqrt{\frac{1 + 36 + 81}{3}} = \sqrt{\frac{118}{3}} = \mathbf{6.27}$$

Spread: no anchor at all

- Wagner (2021): the **sample standard deviation** of your ratings – deviations from your own mean, squared, over $n - 1$
- No in-group required – the only one of the three computable for a non-partisan
- Same four ratings: API 5.33 · Distance 6.27 · Spread 4.24



$$\text{Spread}_i = \sqrt{\frac{16 + 9 + 4 + 25}{3}} = \sqrt{18} = 4.24$$

Two critiques that matter

- What is “affect”? Like/dislike blends emotion with cognitive and instrumental evaluation
- It collapses anger, fear, disgust and contempt – emotions with opposite behavioral implications (Bakker and Lelkes 2024)
- Which target? Asked about a party, respondents picture elites and activists – not the neighbour who rarely discusses politics (Druckman and Levendusky 2019)
- Name the *ordinary* partisan and estimated hostility drops sharply
- So: much measured “mass animosity” may be **elite animosity wearing a costume**

Two dimensions, four different questions

Target (Areal and Harteveld 2024; Reiljan et al. 2024) crossed with measurement mode – the literature crowds into one cell

	Attitudinal what people say	Behavioral what people do
Vertical parties & leaders	Feeling thermometer party like/dislike	Candidate-choice conjoints Donation & campaign tasks Vote choice, turnout
Horizontal ordinary citizens	Social distance items "would you mind if your child married one?"	Allocation games cooperation, solidarity, trust Dating & hiring

Nearly the entire comparative AP literature sits in the top-left cell

Affective Polarization in Europe

Data

- Hahm et al. (2024): cross-national conjoint experiment
- All 25 EU member states, ~29,800 respondents, fielded May–August 2019
- ~1,200 per country, broadly representative on age and gender
- Respondents play incentivized-format allocation games
- Rare combination: comparative scope **and** behavioral outcomes

Design

	Player 2
Nationality	United Kingdom
Age	18
Party Affiliation	Labour Party (Labour)
Gender	Female
Religion	Muslim
Social Class	Middle Class

So put the number of tokens you wish to keep in the box labeled "Player 1." Put the tokens you wish to go to Player 2 in the box labeled "Player 2."

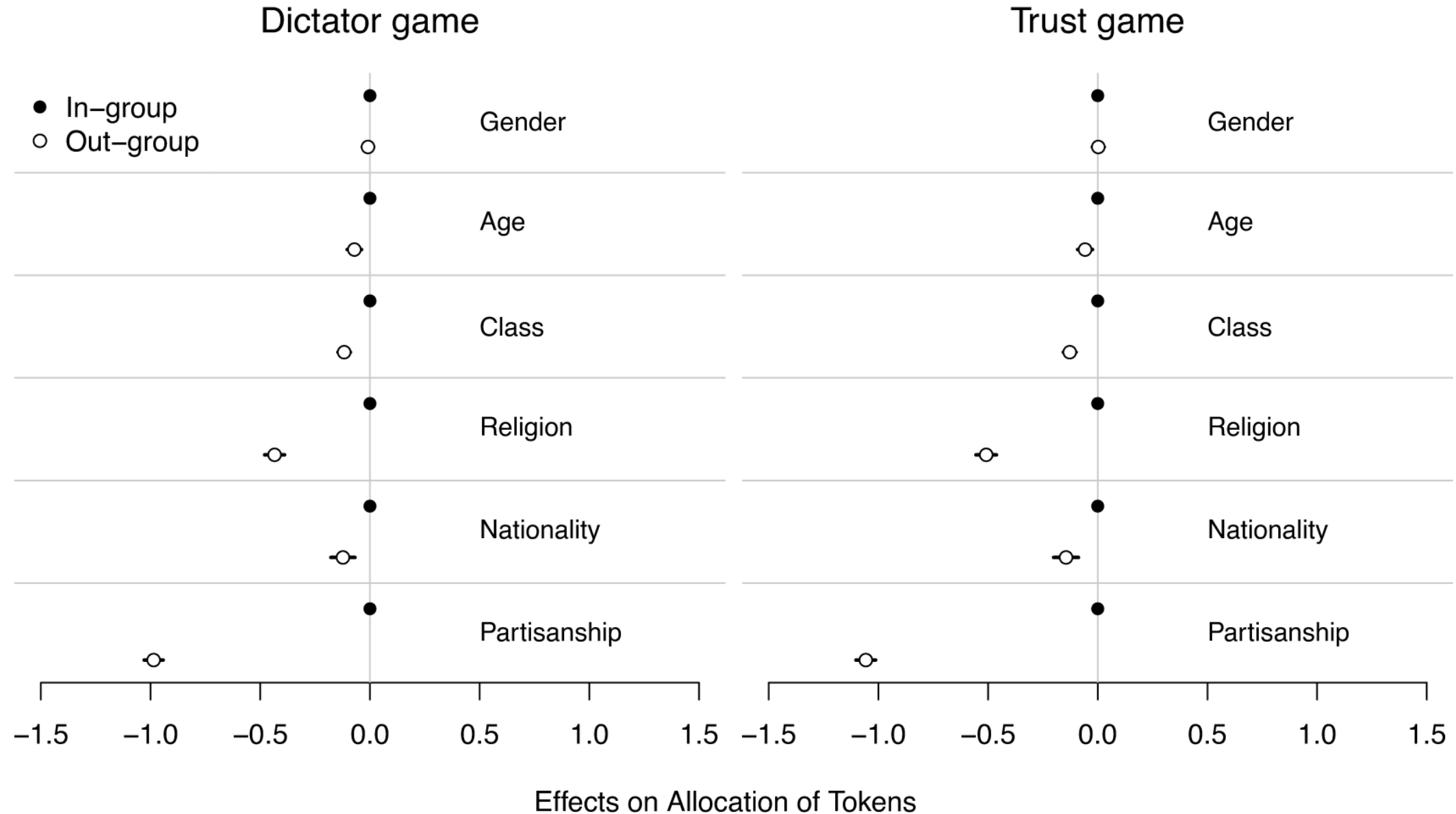
Player 1 (You)	0	Token(s)
Player 2	0	Token(s)
Total	0	Token(s)

Note: Figure from Hahm et al. (2024), Figure 1.

Why this beats a thermometer

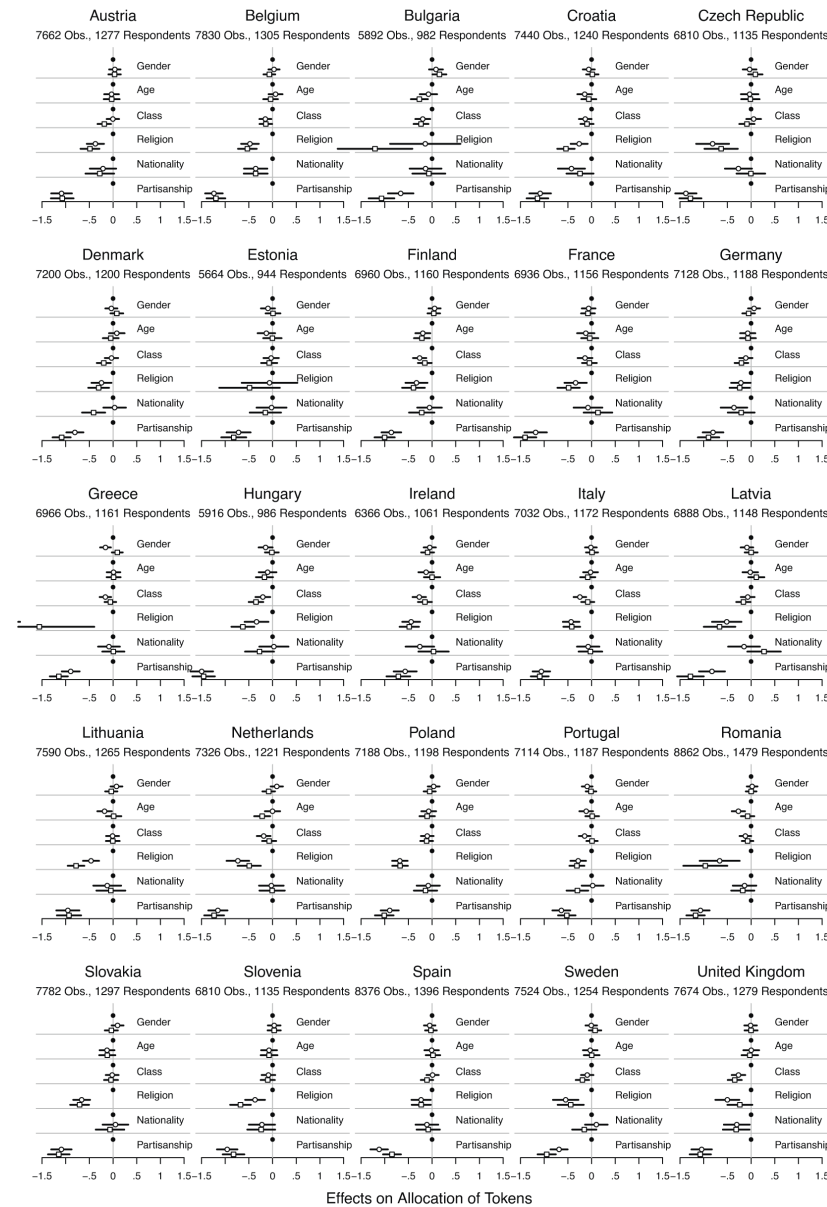
- Explicitly **horizontal**: the co-player is an ordinary co-national
- Explicitly **behavioral**: tokens, not a self-reported feeling
- A **non-partisan baseline** condition – party simply not shown
- So in-group favoritism and out-group derogation are estimated *separately*
- Conjoint reduces social desirability bias ([Horiuchi et al. 2022](#)), and randomization identifies causal effects ([Hainmueller et al. 2014](#))

Partisanship dominates every other divide



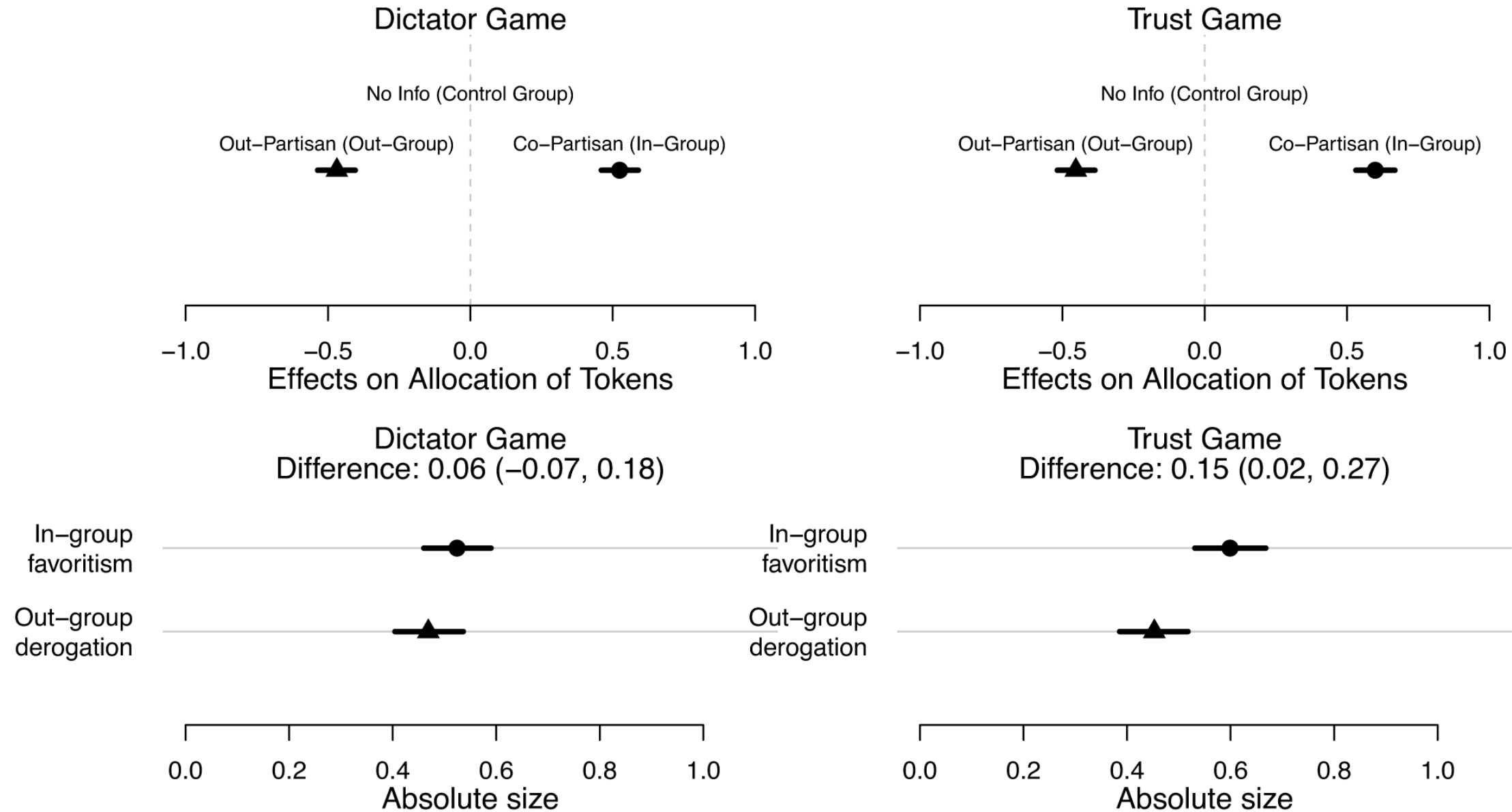
Note: Figure from Hahm et al. (2024), Figure 2. Pooled, J = 29,827, N = 178,936.

...in all 25 democracies



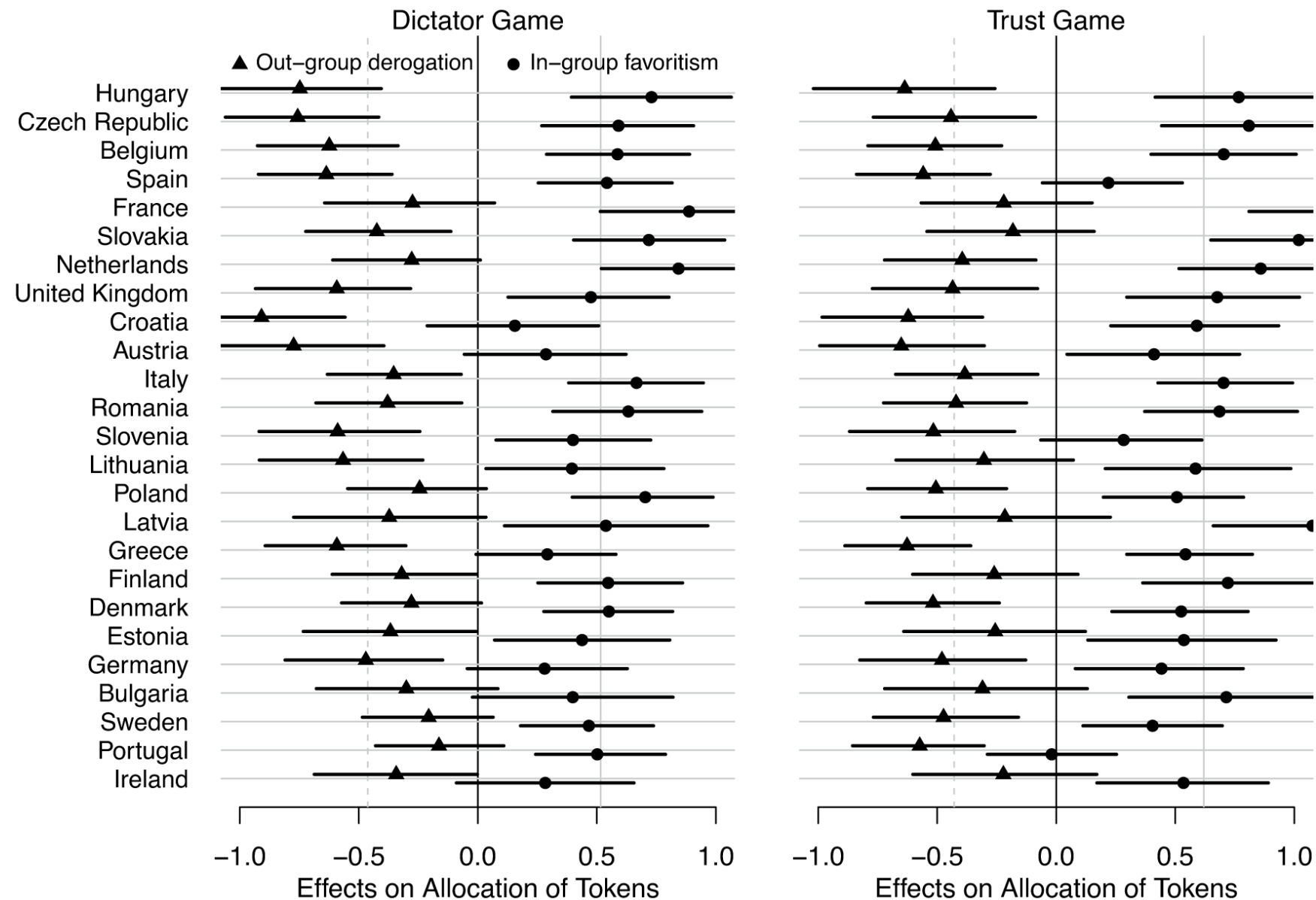
Note: Figure from Hahm et al. (2024), Figure 3. Dots = dictator game, squares = trust game.

In-group favoritism vs out-group derogation



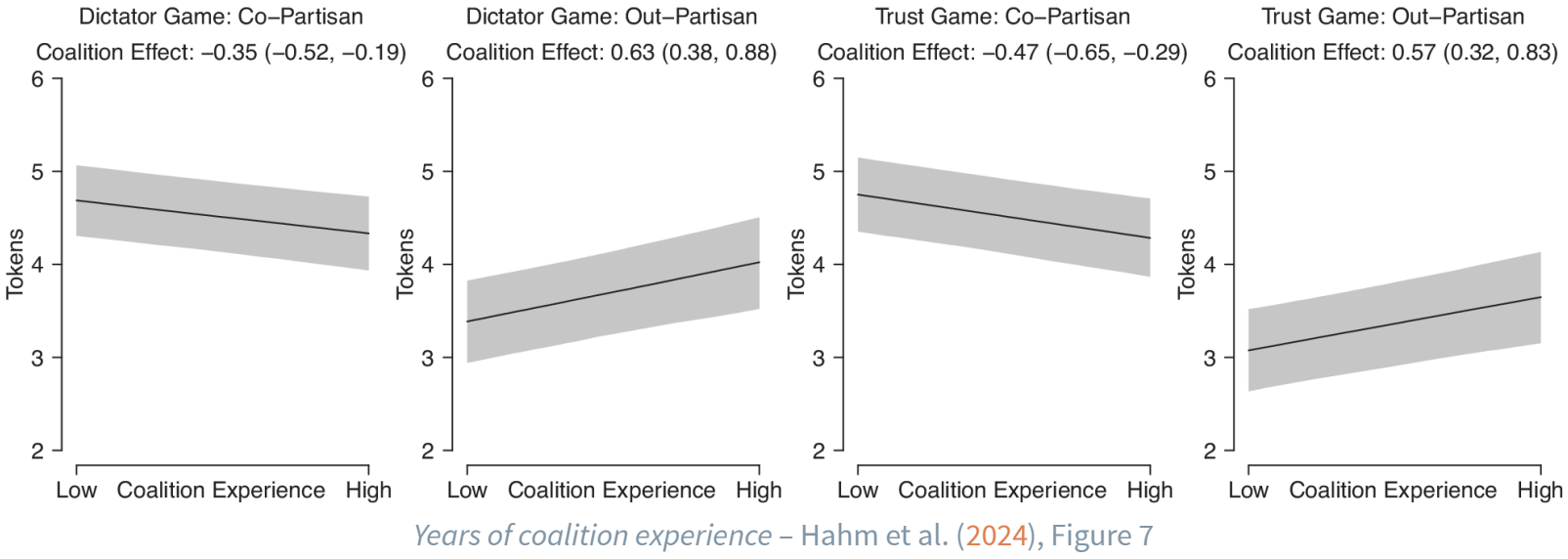
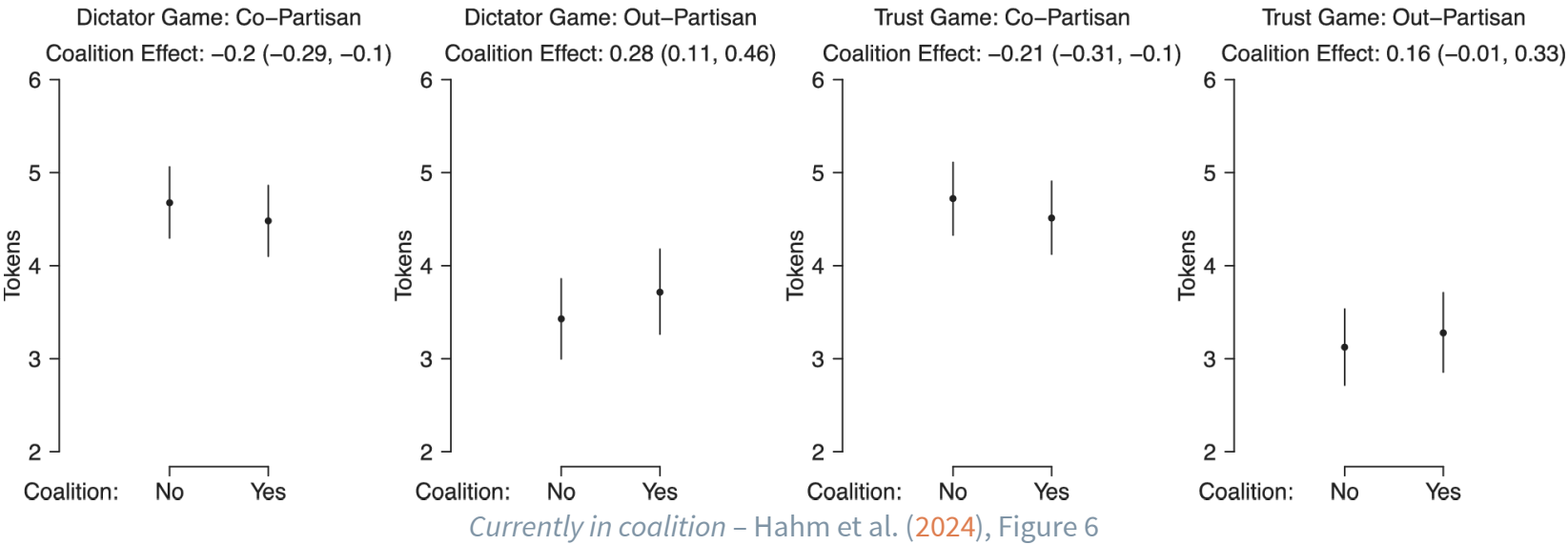
Note: Figure from Hahm et al. (2024), Figure 4. Partisan identifiers only. J = 18,925, N = 77,456.

The decomposition, country by country



Note: Figure from Hahm et al. (2024), Figure 5. Circles = in-group favoritism, triangles = out-group derogation.

Why the variation? Coalitions



A snapshot, not a trend

- Fielded **2019** – pre-COVID, pre-Ukraine, pre-inflation, pre much of the current radical-right wave
- A **state**, not a process – one measurement, no time series
- And one cell of the grid: **horizontal** (an ordinary co-national, not a party or a leader) and **behavioral**
- How any of this has moved since 2019 is a separate, open question

Takeaways

Is it bad for democracy? Depends which one you mean

- The concern: less compromise, lower institutional confidence (**Finkel et al. 2020**)
- The pushback: reducing animosity does **not** move democratic attitudes (**Broockman et al. 2023**)
- The guardrail case: hostility to anti-democratic parties may be healthy (**Harteveld et al. 2022**)
- Agonistic vs antagonistic – adversary or enemy (**Mouffe 2013**)
- **One thermometer number cannot tell any of these apart**

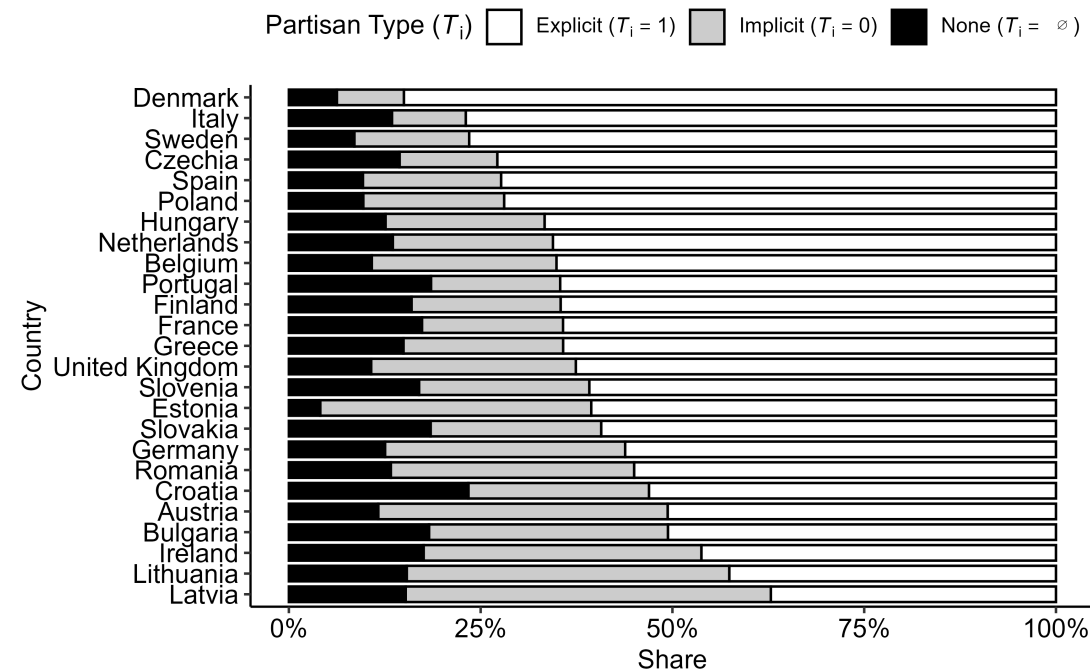
Five things to take with you

- Polarization is a family of concepts, not a thing
- Measurement choices are theoretical choices
- Target **and** mode both matter – vertical/horizontal $\times$ attitudinal/behavioral give different answers about the same people
- In Europe, in-group favoritism is at least as large as out-group derogation – the US out-group-animus story does not simply travel
- Whether AP is “bad for democracy” depends on which AP you mean

Where I Go From Here

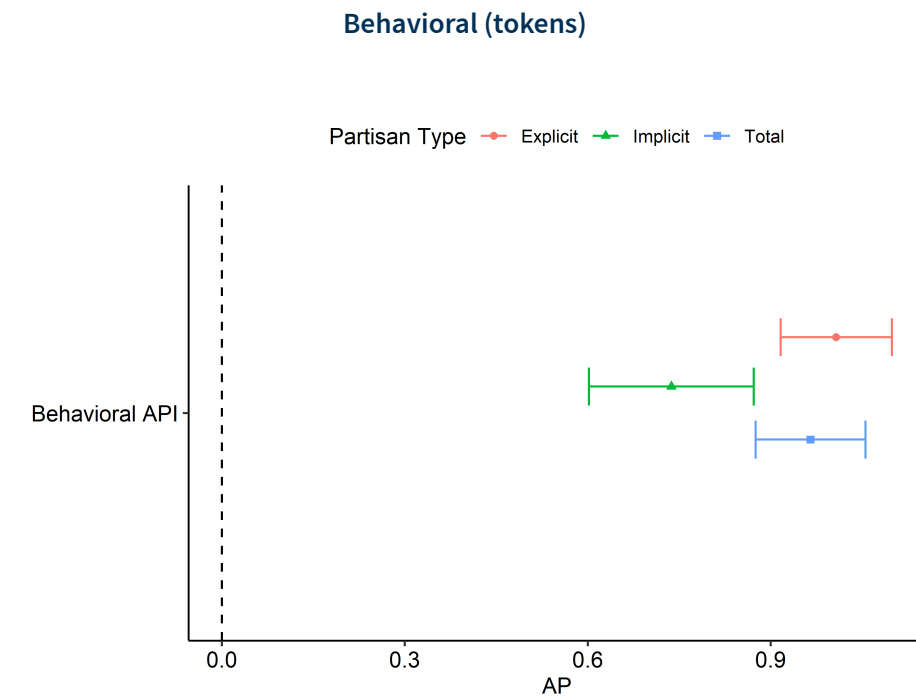
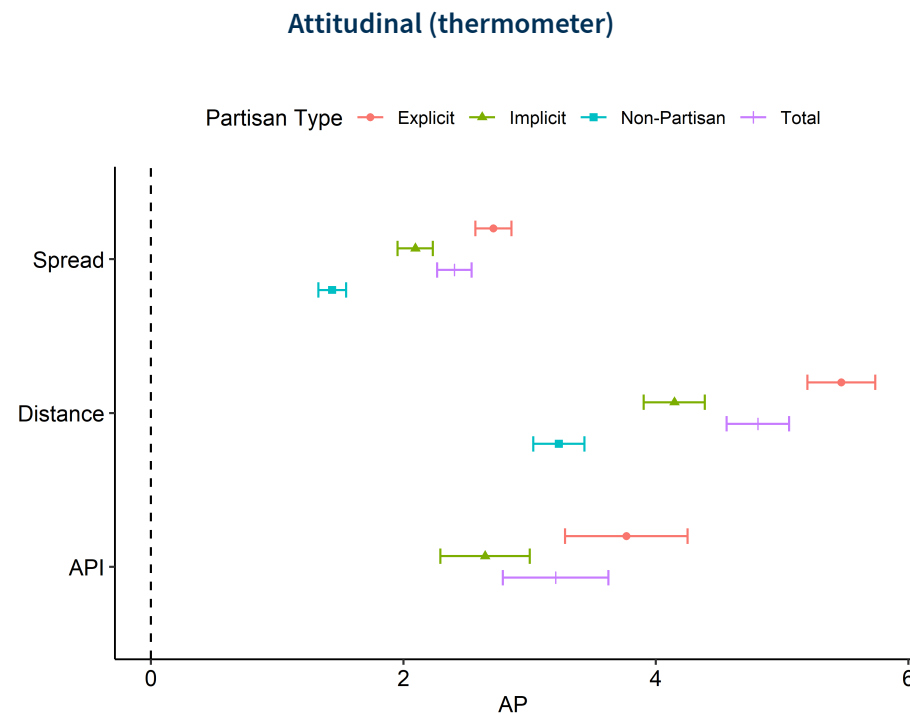
Who counts as a partisan...

- AP is measured **on partisans** – someone must decide who counts
- The usual filter: “do you feel close to a party?”
- Yes-shares run from ~40% to over 80% across member states
- So the choice moves the **population of inference** – unevenly



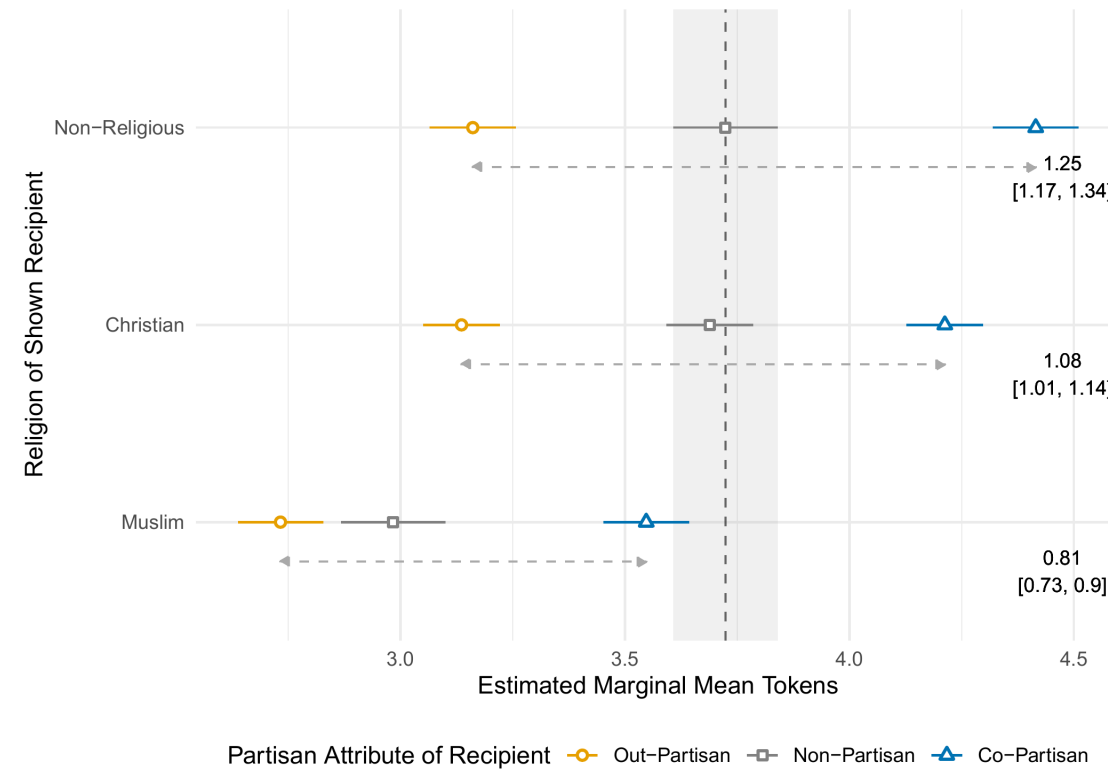
...and how does this influence AP estimates?

- Hold the vote anchor constant, vary only whether attachment is **reported**
- **Attitudinal**: self-identified partisans sit higher on all three thermometer measures
- **Behavioral**: both types withhold roughly 0.7–1.0 tokens from an out-partisan
- **Preliminary** – pooled cross-national descriptives, not yet the within-party test



Partisan sorting and the Muslim penalty

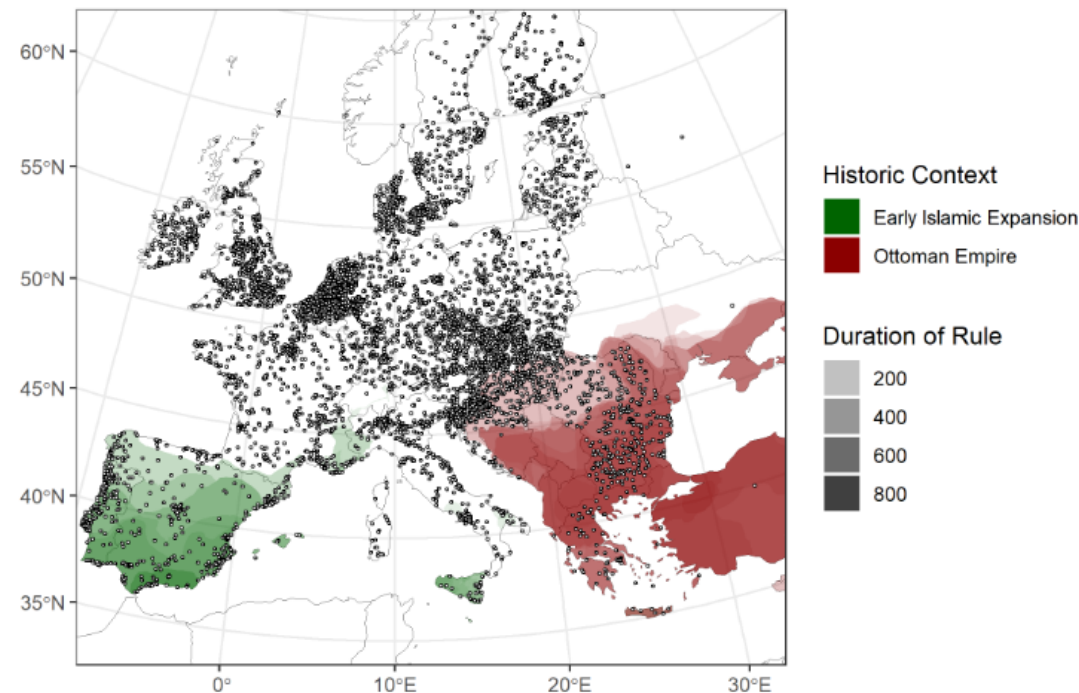
- The conjoint randomizes religion **and** partisanship independently – the interaction is directly estimable
- **Preliminary:** a Muslim cue costs a *co-partisan* more (−0.67 tokens) than an *out-partisan* (−0.41)
- So the partisan gap **narrows**: 1.08 tokens for Christian targets, 0.81 for Muslim ones
- **Planned:** reweight to the joint distribution of party × religion that actually exists, then test for floor effects



Estimated marginal means with 95% CIs, trust game. Preliminary.

Historical Muslim rule and anti-Muslim bias

- Respondents are **geocoded** – linkable to regions once under Muslim rule
- Question: is behavioral anti-Muslim bias *attenuated* where contact ran for centuries?
- Treatment as a **probabilistic surface**, not a crisp polygon – source uncertainty carried into the estimate
- **Planned, no estimates yet** – the map shows the variation and coverage the design rests on



Historical extent and duration of Muslim rule. Black points are georeferenced respondents. *Planned project – no estimates yet.*

Thank you for your attention!

I warmly welcome any feedback, ideas, or critical thoughts ♥



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